

Slaughter and May

Complete firm and application research — the multi-specialist model, M&A/takeover record, international reach, values, sustainability, notable deals, application process and personal notes.

- Model:** Full-service global law firm for corporate clients — multi-specialist, not siloed
- Billing:** No billing or time targets for lawyers
- Reputation:** Pre-eminent firm for UK public takeovers; more listed-company clients than any other UK firm
- Application essay:** "Why are you interested in becoming a Solicitor Apprentice at Slaughter and May?" (500 words)

1. Firm Overview	—
2. M&A & Takeover Track Record	—
3. The Multi-Specialist Model	—
4. International Reach	—
5. Practice Areas & Sectors	—
6. Culture & Values	—
7. Sustainability & Social Mobility	—
8. Innovation & Legal Tech	—
9. Notable Deals	—
10. Trainee & Associate Perspectives	—
11. Horizon Scanning Topics	—
12. Rotation Structure	—
13. Preparation Steps Recommended	—
14. Application Essay — Breakdown	—
15. CV & Situational Judgement Test	—
16. Personal Fit & Application Angles	—

1. Firm Overview

- A full-service global law firm for corporate clients — specialising across a number of practice areas (Financing, Corporate, Competition, Disputes) so lawyers can work with clients across many areas of law
- Acts for more listed companies than any other law firm — experience built over years that other firms find difficult to match
- Clients range from governments to entrepreneurs, retailers to entertainment companies, and conglomerates to Premier League football clubs
- No billing or time targets for lawyers — time is recorded, but lawyers are not forced to compete for the jobs or clients that bill the most hours, allowing greater emphasis on quality, efficiency and shared expertise

2. M&A & Takeover Track Record

- Widely regarded as the pre-eminent law firm for UK public takeovers — covering all sizes and types, from international, cross-border and domestic to hostile, recommended and reverse takeovers
- In the last five years, acted for more targets of unsolicited approaches than any other law firm
- Acted on the nine largest UK M&A deals in 2018
- Regularly the most active law firm in the takeover area — acted on more takeover situations/approaches in the UK in the first half of 2024 than any other firm

Headline transactions

- **Shire plc** — advised on its takeover by Takeda Pharmaceutical Company Limited, a court-sanctioned scheme of arrangement valuing Shire's share capital at approximately £46 billion, with Shire shareholders ending up owning roughly 50% of Takeda
- **The Walt Disney Company** — advised on English law aspects of its \$85 billion acquisition of Twenty-First Century Fox, Inc., and Fox's involvement in the £30 billion takeover battle for Sky plc

3. The Multi-Specialist Model

As a trainee or solicitor apprentice, you work across the full range of transactions a group advises on — in Corporate, one month might mean helping defend a hostile takeover, the next advising the same client on an equity issue; in Disputes, a morning could mean a civil litigation hearing, an afternoon preparing a client for mediation.

- In the short term, this variety helps you make a more informed decision about which practice group to join on qualification
- In the long term, it makes for a more fulfilling career — providing challenge, deeper client relationships (through better understanding of their business), and a guiding role in changing commercial and legal times
- It is hard work, with exacting standards — but the collegiate approach means support is always available
- The financing team specifically sets itself apart by focusing on client relationships rather than siloed financing practice areas, deploying smaller, versatile teams drawing on DCM, securitisation, derivatives and tax specialists

Finance basics: Equity finance = an investor funds a business project in exchange for a share of ownership. Debt finance = a business borrows money (e.g. from a bank) that must be repaid over time, usually with interest, without diluting ownership.

4. International Reach

- Works with more than 200 law firms across 100 countries annually — this frequency of overseas engagement gives lawyers, including trainees, international contacts and local insight not possible in a "one-stop-shop" global firm model
- Many trainees and associates have the opportunity to work abroad, either in Slaughter and May's own offices or at a global relationship firm
- Secondments are seen as especially valuable because they expose lawyers to a working culture very different from the firm's own
- The London office also hosts an intake of secondees from overseas relationship firms twice yearly, giving London lawyers regular day-to-day exposure to international peers
- The firm invests heavily in these relationships through regular travel, long-running secondment programmes, and joint initiatives/expertise sharing — supported by "Country Teams" that trainees and associates can proactively join
- Real examples from trainees/associates: secondments to Mannheimer Swartling (Stockholm), New York, the Middle East, Brussels, and Hong Kong

5. Practice Areas & Sectors

CORPORATE	FINANCING	COMPETITION	DISPUTES	MEDIA & TELECOMS	PRIVATE EQUITY	CONSUMER & RETAIL	ASSET MANAGEMENT
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Consumer & Retail

Full-service corporate, commercial and financing advice, often working alongside leading independent law firms worldwide whose

values, standards and status match the firm's own. Led by partners with diverse, specialist expertise to anticipate each client's individual legal needs. The multi-specialist approach means fewer people are needed per transaction, giving clients a single point of contact who works closely with specialists from other market-leading practice areas (financing, pensions, real estate, IP/IT, tax, financial regulation, dispute resolution) as needed. Key clients include **Ocado, M&S, and Watches of Switzerland**.

| Private Equity

Communication and efficiency are key to a successful PE transaction. The approach is flexible but always partner-led, with personal relationships and genuine value-add at the core. Notable mandate: advising Her Majesty's Government (including HM Treasury and the Cabinet Office) on establishing and investing in funds to finance infrastructure projects, including the £400m Digital Infrastructure Fund and the £400m Charging Infrastructure Investment Fund for electric vehicles.

| Corporate

Covers strategic M&A, corporate governance, private equity and takeovers — requiring commercial-mindedness and client focus, working alongside colleagues with complementary specialisms. Described as a steep learning curve that stays engaging due to the constantly evolving nature of the work, with progressively greater responsibility and direct client engagement over time.

6. Culture & Values

- **The highest standards** — exacting standards for work and performance, conducted with integrity, responsibility and candour
- **Independence of thought** — thrives on original thinking and novel approaches; welcomes diversity of experience and viewpoint
- **Collective endeavour** — intentionally collaborative and supportive; encourages personal initiative but prizes collegiality over competition
- **Respect for all** — fair, considerate and inclusive; attentive to others' needs and mindful of the consequences of actions

The atmosphere here is friendly and supportive — everyone's contribution is valued and we believe strongly in the importance of personal respect. We also believe that people should enjoy their work.

— Firm statement

No two days are the same; the multi-specialist approach means constant variety and intellectual engagement, with new developments arising unexpectedly.

7. Sustainability & Social Mobility

Sustainability is being integrated into the firm's strategic and operational decisions, so it becomes part of everyday business activity. Six sustainability priorities: **gender equality, reduced inequality, climate action, peace/justice/strong institutions, responsible consumption and production, and decent work and economic growth**.

- Works with community partners to support literacy, academic attainment and access to education, and helps individuals into work, self-employment and training
- Helps build the capacity and financial sustainability of partner charities, with a focus on local needs like homelessness and food poverty
- Encourages employee volunteering, Payroll Giving, and a "Funds for Fundraisers" matched-funding programme
- **The first major law firm to set social mobility targets** — publishing socio-economic diversity targets to be more intentional in recruiting irrespective of background, and to stay accountable for delivering change

We all want to live and work in a society where hard work and talent are what get you ahead, irrespective of background characteristics including socio-economic background.

— Firm statement

8. Innovation & Legal Tech

- **Collaborate** — a programme open to innovators and entrepreneurs with legal-sector-relevant products; cohort members get to test and develop their product, gain detailed feedback, build network connections, and pitch for investment via **Slaughter and May Ventures**, the firm's investment platform
- **Fast Forward** — the firm's emerging tech incubation programme, supporting technology entrepreneurs and innovators whose businesses could deliver meaningful improvement or competition across sectors
- Internal AI tools include tools to analyse emails, a contract tool (built on Canva), and a pricing/profitability tool — all built specifically for lawyers rather than technologists

9. Notable Deals

- **Attarat Power Company** — advised Attarat and project sponsors Eesti Energia AS and YTL Power International Berhad on construction and project financing of the first oil-shale-fired power station in Jordan; \$2.1bn investment value, \$1.6bn debt financing from a syndicate of Chinese banks; worked on the project for nearly three and a half years (including numerous trips to Jordan and China) before it closed in 2017, covering project financing, commercial contracts, equity sell-down and shareholder arrangements
- **Seadrill** — advised one of the world's largest offshore drilling contractors on a comprehensive restructuring plan, involving a vast

scope and an extremely complex structure requiring close teamwork to complete

10. Trainee & Associate Perspectives

Composite notes from published trainee/associate accounts and networking conversations — useful colour for understanding day-to-day life at the firm.

- The Commercial Law Virtual Insight Programme is often cited as a deciding factor in applying — exposing candidates to the firm's agile, multi-specialist approach and lack of billing targets, which stood out versus other corporate firms feeling similar to one another
- Corporate work allows seeing deals through start to finish — from early-stage due diligence through to signing
- Involvement in Business Development work (e.g. assisting with pitches) and the firm's competition newsletter is available to trainees, alongside attending webinars/conferences hosted by bodies like the European Commission
- Secondment opportunities arise in the third or fourth seat — examples include Mannheimer Swartling in Stockholm, New York, and the Middle East
- Being a trainee buddy to work experience students was described as a meaningful full-circle moment for one trainee
- Beyond its prestigious client base, the firm places genuine emphasis on people and a collaborative culture; the multi-specialist approach was repeatedly highlighted as promoting variety and intellectual engagement, and encouraging lateral thinking and willingness to challenge precedent
- Early responsibilities include taking call notes, maintaining trackers, reviewing reports, and drafting correspondence — with a strong emphasis on clear communication from day one
- Participation in Early Careers Recruitment initiatives is common — e.g. panellist appearances at the Legal Cheek Virtual Law Fair, engaging with aspiring trainees
- International secondment destinations mentioned include New York and the Middle East, alongside Hong Kong (Disputes and Investigations sector) and Brussels
- Social mobility work is actively encouraged from trainee level — e.g. mentoring via upReach's Springboard programme, pro bono advice, and involvement in a social mobility network that grew from a sub-committee, seen as evidence of genuine ongoing investment rather than a one-off initiative
- A DIVERSE committee supports diversity work, working closely with recruitment and HR — described as treated as a necessity rather than an ideal

11. Horizon Scanning Topics

The firm publishes ongoing "horizon scanning" analysis to help identify new opportunities, perspectives and risk considerations for clients — useful application research material:

- Takeover trends in 2025
- ESG in APAC (2025)
- The energy dividend — power strategies to maximise data centre investment
- Training data in court — a digital/AI-related case
- Navigating the new cartel enforcement landscape

12. Rotation Structure

As a trainee or solicitor apprentice, you work on the full range of transactions your group advises on, rather than being siloed into one type of work. This is designed to help you make an informed choice of practice group on qualification, and — over the long term — to build deeper client relationships through better business understanding.

13. Preparation Steps Recommended

- Attend one of the firm's online events, part of its virtual event series
- Complete the firm's Explore Law Virtual Insight Programme
- Learn the distinct differences that set the firm apart from other global law firms
- Research some of the firm's recent deals, and consider the role of the legal advisers, the key commercial drivers, and the challenges involved
- Read published accounts of the firm's lawyers' own career experiences for insight into life as a commercial lawyer

14. Application Essay — Breakdown

Core essay prompt: "*Why are you interested in becoming a Solicitor Apprentice at Slaughter and May?*" (500 words). The firm asks for answers across several linked areas:

Understanding of the role

Show awareness that the route is demanding, but that the challenge is worth the reward — resilience, refined skills and knowledge gained; handling multiple simultaneous tasks (study and work) to a high standard; and framing the six-year programme as a long-term

journey of learning, loyalty and gradually increasing responsibility.

| **Personal motivations and enthusiasm**

Link to real personal experience — e.g. exposure to a family business (planning, decision-making, navigating risk), strong performance in A-Level Law/Business, and experience applying legal theory in job simulations across firms and sectors.

| **Understanding of commercial law as a career**

Show that commercial law sits between analytical and people-oriented work — connecting legal theory with business context and client psychology (motivations, decision-making, negotiation), and an interest in creative, not purely theoretical, problem-solving.

| **Understanding of Slaughter and May specifically**

Reference the firm's horizon-scanning content, its multi-specialist approach, sustainability/social mobility commitments, and specific named practice areas or deals — showing genuine, specific research rather than generic firm interest.

| **Strong written communication**

Demonstrate the ability to condense large amounts of information into clear, presentable, transferable material (e.g. via revision techniques, structured notes) — framed as directly transferable to legal writing for clients and colleagues.

Firm guidance: write in your own words, in a professional but natural tone; answer the question asked and link examples back to it directly; reflect on what specifically sparked your interest in law; and proofread carefully — clear, error-free writing makes a strong impression.

15. CV & Situational Judgement Test

| **CV**

No more than two sides of A4, including: a breakdown of GCSE and A-Level grades (stating whether actual or predicted); legal work experience and events (including virtual programmes); non-legal work experience; paid employment; and extracurricular activities.

| **Situational Judgement Test**

Sent within 2 days of submitting the application. Presents 15 scenarios; candidates rank response options from most to least effective. Not timed, but expected to take roughly 30–45 minutes. No legal knowledge is required.

| **Interview process**

- Written exercise
- Interview with lawyers
- Tour of the office with a trainee solicitor
- HR interview

16. Personal Fit & Application Angles

Drafted talking points connecting personal motivations and experience to the firm's positioning — for use/refinement in application answers.

- The most demanding routes tend to yield the most personal growth — drawing on experience taking on intimidating leadership roles (e.g. a marketing team role) and growing into them over time
- A track record of handling multiple demanding commitments alongside academics (marketing team, ambassador role, tutoring, part-time job, house captain) shows discipline, time management and self-motivation without needing external reinforcement
- A genuine interest in actively contributing to firm culture, not just absorbing it — bringing fresh ideas while fitting existing values, especially given how much emphasis the firm places on culture
- A consistent drive to improve — e.g. taking a marketing/leadership role further than expected, or pushing further in academics — mirrors the firm's own "raising the bar" ethos
- Commercial understanding gained through webinars and research: how external forces, client motivations and legal principles interact, rather than treating law as separate from its commercial context
- Studying business alongside law (e.g. SWOT analysis, market understanding) and exposure to a family business's real market pressures gives a practical, not just theoretical, grounding for commercial advice

Sources: slaughterandmay.com practice, insights and careers pages; published trainee/associate accounts; firm application guidance materials. Compiled as private research — verify current application deadlines and process details against the live listing before applying.